Kestrel On-Call Policy

Version 3.0, effective 2026-10-01. Owner: @kestrel/platform-team. Replaces version 2.1 (OPS-51, closed 2026-10-01). Reviewed every six months.

1. Purpose

This policy defines who is on call for Kestrel production, how incidents are classified, how quickly we respond, and how we escalate to the team that owns the failing code. It exists because two incidents in 2026 (double booking on 2026-06-14, gateway 429 storm on 2026-08-21) lost time finding the right people.

2. Rotation

- Two roles each week: **primary** and **secondary**, both from `@kestrel/platform-team`.
- Weeks run Monday 10:00 UTC to Monday 10:00 UTC. Handover follows `runbooks/on-call-handover.md`.
- Booking, pricing and web each name one **service contact** per week who can be paged for questions about their service. Service contacts are not first responders.
- Engineers join the rotation after shadowing two weeks and completing the runbook walk-through (db-failover and deploy-rollback drills).
- Maximum of one primary week in four. Nobody is primary two weeks running.

3. Severity levels

Level	Definition	Examples
SEV1	Customers cannot book or get quotes at all, or data is being corrupted	All carriers rejected; database down
SEV2	Major degradation for many customers or one carrier fully down	Quote error rate over 20%; duplicate reservations
SEV3	Minor degradation with a workaround	One page slow; delayed notification
SEV4	No customer impact	Alert noise, cosmetic defect

When unsure, pick the higher severity and downgrade later.

4. Response targets

Level	Acknowledge	First update	Updates	Postmortem
SEV1	5 minutes	15 minutes	every 15 minutes	within 5 business days
SEV2	15 minutes	30 minutes	every 30 minutes	within 5 business days
SEV3	4 business hours	next business day	as needed	optional
SEV4	next business day	n/a	n/a	no

Targets apply 24x7 for SEV1 and SEV2.

5. Escalation by owning team

The primary escalates to the team that owns the failing path as defined in `CODEOWNERS` and ADR-0009. Do not wait to prove the cause before paging.

Symptom area	Page
Reservations, carriers, rate limiter, advisory lock	`@kestrel/booking-team`
Quotes, tariffs, surcharges, rounding	`@kestrel/pricing-team`

Symptom area	Page
Gateway errors, timeouts, translation	`@kestrel/platform-team` (secondary)
UI errors	`@kestrel/web-team`
Architecture or cross-service decision	`@kestrel/architecture-guild` (next business day)

Page the owning team after **10 minutes** without a clear owner-independent fix for SEV1, and after **20 minutes** for SEV2. The primary stays incident commander until the incident is handed off explicitly.

6. Incident roles

- **Incident commander (IC):** the primary by default. Coordinates, decides, communicates.
- **Operations lead:** hands-on fixer, typically from the owning team.
- **Communications:** posts in `#kestrel-incidents` and the status page; for SEV1 a secondary takes this role.

7. During an incident

1. Acknowledge the page and open a thread in `#kestrel-incidents` with severity.
2. Stabilise first: mitigate (roll back, flip flag, lower rate) before root-causing.
3. Keep a timeline in UTC in the thread.
4. Any manual override gets a ticket, an owner and an expiry.
5. Never disable safety controls such as `kestrel.booking.lock.enabled` without the booking-team lead's written approval.
6. Close with a summary and the customer-facing statement.

8. Postmortems

Blameless and written within five business days for SEV1 and SEV2, using the template from OPS-44. File as `postmortems/YYYY-MM-DD-slug.md`. Every action item has a ticket and an owner. The owning team of the code decides the remediation; the author may be anyone.

9. Load and fairness

- On-call hours outside 08:00 to 20:00 local time earn compensatory time off.
- After a page between 00:00 and 06:00 local time, the engineer starts late the next day.
- If a week has more than 5 out-of-hours pages, platform-team leadership reviews whether the alert set needs tuning.

10. Contacts

- Paging: the paging tool's `kestrel-primary` and `kestrel-secondary` schedules.
- Chat: `#kestrel-oncall` (coordination), `#kestrel-incidents` (live incidents).
- Carrier escalation contacts: `sla/carrier-sla.pdf`.

11. Change history

Version	Date	Change
3.0	2026-10-01	Rewrite: owner-based escalation, explicit timers (OPS-51)
2.1	2026-02-12	Added secondary role

Version	Date	Change
2.0	2025-11-03	Split from kestrel-core on-call after ADR-0001